

# APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



# Transition management

## Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Transition Management competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of Transition Management as the process of managing the handover of the project outputs commissioned and accepted by the sponsor, culminating in formal closure.

## Learning objective and outcomes

### Learning objective:

8. Understand transition management as integration of the outputs of a project into business-as-usual.

### By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

8a) Know the basic requirements needed to support a successful transition, including considering business-as-usual throughout a project and planning for transition from the outset of the project.

8b) Understand the importance of knowledge transfer in the transition process; this includes learning from experience and continuous improvement.

8c) Understand how to engage stakeholders to agree a transition plan, including transfer of risks.

## Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 2 - 3 hours to complete.

## Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Transition Management:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition 2.3.1 (Business readiness), 2.3.2 (Transition of project outputs)
- APM What is change management and organisational change?  
<https://www.apm.org.uk/resources/what-is-project-management/what-is-change-management/>
- APM Managing effective change <https://youtu.be/WIPsgegZ5Mk>

## Overview

Transition management involves the planning and execution of activities necessary for a smooth shift of the outputs of a project into business-as-usual.

Effective transition management considers the co-ordination of resources, communication strategies, and risk mitigation to ensure a seamless transition with minimal disruption to the day-to-day activities of an organisation.

The process requires a strategic approach, meticulous planning, as well as a proactive and pragmatic approach to problem solving to address any changes and challenges that may arise during the project transition phase.

## Supporting a Successful Transition

The below are actions that should be taken to ensure a 'smooth transition' of any project into the operational environment:

- Managing stakeholder expectations from the outset to increase the likelihood of the project outputs being accepted.
- Identifying and engaging with end users and project sponsors as key stakeholders throughout the project.
- Aligning needs with outputs where project constraints allow and communicating any digression from these.
- Setting the path for handover and acceptance by familiarising key stakeholders with the deliverables from the outset.
- Clear communication to reduce the risk of the project manager misunderstanding the requirements or the end users of the deliverables.

Preparing for the new 'business-as-usual' should also be considered early in the project life cycle.

Business readiness should be considered as a continuous activity throughout the project to ensure 'buy in' from the users of the project outputs and those who will be expected to do things differently.

Techniques such as change impact analysis will help determine the following:

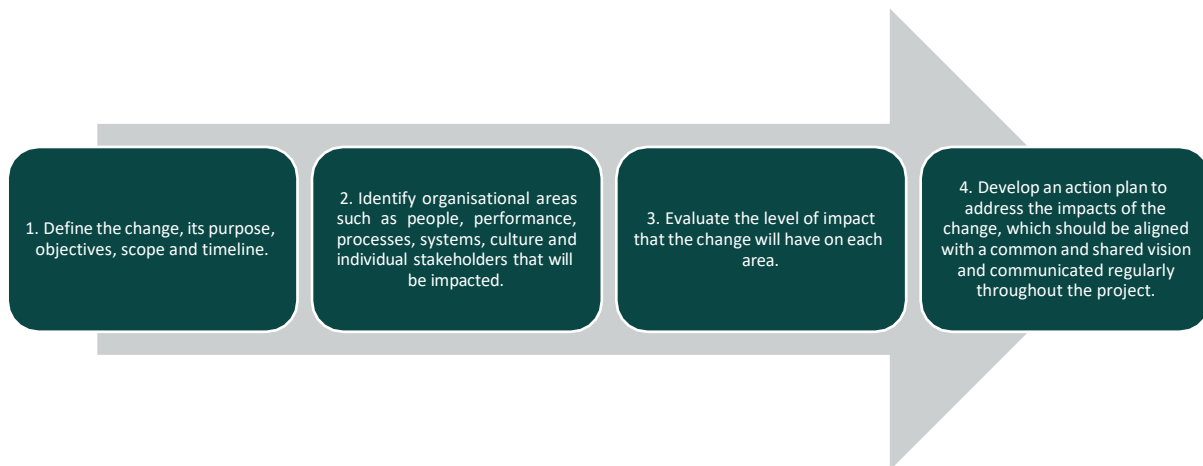
- Physical or process impacts on the wider system
- Feelings about the change
- Knowledge gaps or skills needs to be addressed

## Change Impact Analysis

Change impact analysis is a method of analysing the scope and scale of the change to the new business-as-usual state.

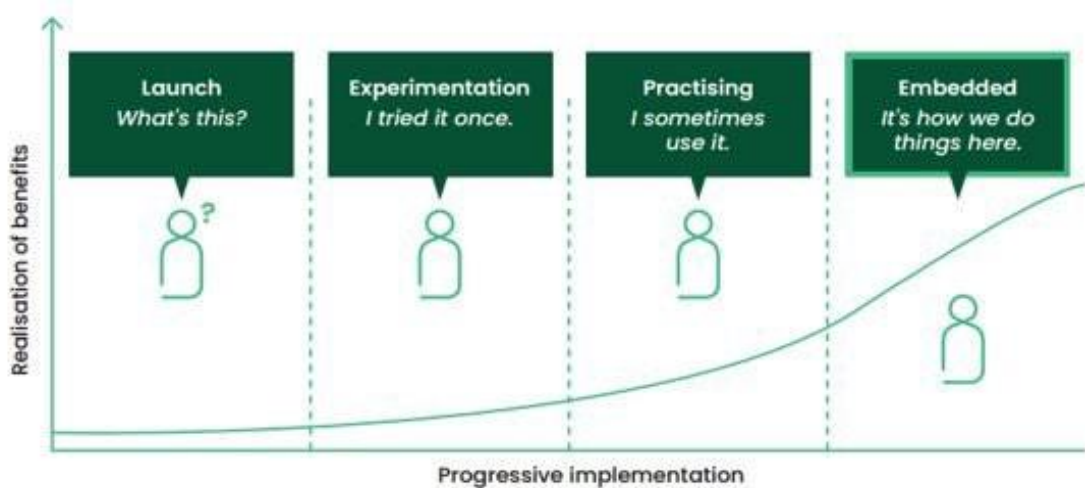
It helps to understand the organisational impacts on people, performance, processes, systems and culture.

It will support the planning and communication of change effectively, identifying potential issues and highlighting the resources required to do this.



## Progressive Implementation

Knowledge transfer is the process of sharing information, skills and expertise from the project team to the operational users. This is often a progressive implementation, when skills are firstly launched, experimentation takes place, skills are practised and finally, the new ways of working are embedded.



It's important to consider the following:

- The relationship between the people responsible for deployment of new capabilities and those responsible for business readiness and adoption in business-as-usual should be carefully managed as part of governance.
- The sponsor is a key champion of this work to align the temporary project team and the functional and operational teams in the business to ensure the transfer of knowledge can take place.
- An extended life cycle approach would make the project team accountable for change management and therefore prevents the formation of knowledge boundaries between project teams and operational teams.
- It is important to provide effective learning and development from experience so that knowledge can be transferred to nurture future talent and users of the project outputs and to promote continuous improvement.

## Transition Planning

Transition planning starts at the beginning of a project.

Information provided by the investing organisation is used to shape the solutions and plans, including details of what needs to be handed back to the organisation at the point of transition.

The Transition process may include:

- Acceptance of all pertinent documentation (containing all prescribed information related to the deliverables, including guarantees and warranties).
- Acceptance Certificates signed by the sponsor. This is an agreement between two parties that states the tasks that need to be completed and the criteria that must be met to get final approval at the end of the project
- Transfer of responsibility for the deliverables from the project team to the sponsor or users
- Formal transfer of ownership

Providing detailed and thorough guidance and resources is a crucial part of the handover process.

The information provided at handover for linear projects, or at relevant points of a project delivered under an iterative life cycle can include:

- Process Maps
- Project Documentation
- Ownership of Supplier Relationships
- Ongoing Licensing Arrangements

As an example, for a building project, the handover information might include the following:

- User Manuals
- Operating Procedures and Maintenance Manuals
- Asset Registers
- Design Information in the form of Architectural and / or Engineering Drawings
- Survey Information
- Health & Safety Files
- Warranty Information and Commissioning Certificates

In addition, training on new systems, software and knowledge transfer should be organised by the project manager to the users at the time of transition or at an appropriate point in the life cycle, for example, in an iterative or hybrid project, training and knowledge transfer may be required frequently, and before the end of a project.

## **Engaging Stakeholders in a Transition Plan**

Engaging stakeholders in a transition plan plays a crucial part in the overall success of incorporating the change into the operational environment.

It involves identifying, communicating with and involving users (individuals or groups) who have a vested interest in the project's outcomes.

### **Early engagement**

It is important to engage the relevant stakeholders early in the project. Stakeholder mapping will help to identify those that will be impacted by or interested in the transition process e.g., Senior Leaders who will drive the transition, or departmental change agents providing personalised transition leadership experience to colleagues, consisting of those with existing or new roles.

### **Strategic alignment of goals and understanding of the future state**

Collaborative planning with stakeholders throughout the project will help to develop a shared vision, a common understanding of the organisational strategic impact, benefits and financial value goals expected.

### **Communicating benefits**

Communicating benefits to stakeholders from an early stage in the project will support the development of the common understanding. Designating a benefits champion can support the communication of expected benefits with stakeholders throughout the project and help to prepare them for the transition process.

## **Considerations when agreeing a Transition Plan with Stakeholders**

### **Agreeing a Benefits Management Plan**

A benefits management plan will define how the benefits will be managed through transition into operational use and the roles and responsibilities involved; benefits should be documented in terms of priority inter-dependencies, value, timescales, and ownership. Techniques such as MoSCoW (M – Must have; S – Should have; C – Could have; W – Won't have) can be used.

### **Mitigating Conflict**

The possibility of conflict between the user and the project manager should be considered, this may occur if the project does not meet its acceptance criteria, or user expectations.

### **Transfer of Risk**

Any remaining risks at project closure should be communicated to those involved in the adoption phase.

## **Transition Planning with Stakeholders and Life Cycle**

When engaging stakeholders in a transition plan, it's also important to consider the life cycle that has been used through the duration of the project and how it may potentially impact transition planning.

Here are some considerations depending on the life cycle that has been used:

### **Linear Life cycles**

Transition planning should be a continuous activity through the life cycle.

In linear life cycles, the final desired state or project output is only available during the transition (final) phase of the project and therefore it is important to monitor progress and alignment of deliverables against expectations through assurance and governance procedures over the course of the project life cycle at regular review points.

### **Iterative Life cycles**

Iterative life cycles provide the opportunity for the project manager to build stakeholder buy-in on an ongoing basis whether this be collaborative input to a design or ideas from business-as-usual about the implementation schedule.



**Scenario One:**

Excitement is building within the Snappy Appy senior leadership team as the start date for the renovation project gets closer!

Ayo, the Founder/CEO, is already looking forward to the completion of the project and the expansion opportunities that it will present in the future.

They know that the project will require a lot of work and will be disruptive to the day-to-day operation of the business but are willing to endure this knowing that it will mean 'bigger and better' things!

Once the renovation is completed, Ayo (and the rest of the senior leadership team) want the transition to be as smooth as possible with minimal impacts on staff and productivity.

**What steps could you implement to ensure a 'smooth' transition once the renovations are completed?**

**As the project manager, what is your role in relation to these steps?**

**Scenario Two:**

Sandeep, the Head of Development has heard that you are working with Ayo to put into place steps that will ensure that the handover process following the renovation happens with as small an impact as possible.

Sandeep is a very detail focused individual and often talks about the fact that “all good coders and developers have an insatiable thirst for knowledge and understanding”. They know that they do the ‘lion’s share’ of the work in the company and are worried about the effect on their team members and ultimately their ability to continue to perform.

They also freely admit that in times of stress, they look for this even more – this is the biggest project that Snappy Appy has been involved in since its inception and they want to make sure that they know everything about the implications for their team of developers.

To reassure Sandeep, you tell them that you will put together a change analysis report and walk them through the potential considerations.

**What potential factors do you think should be included in the report? Why do you feel that these factors should be included?**

**How could you assess the impact of the proposed changes on the Sandeep and their team?**

**Scenario Three:**

The senior leadership team know how important employee engagement is and how much of an influence 'buy in' from the whole Snappy Appy team will have on the ease of the transition following the renovation as well as morale during the disruptive building phase.

They've asked that you develop a regular update tool that can be sent to all employees giving them the latest information about the renovation project, how it's progressing, what they can expect following transition, etc.

**Draft an outline for the update tool, including the kinds of subjects to ensure that stakeholders are both informed and enthused about the renovation project and its impact.**

**What method would you suggest to the senior leadership to distribute the regular update and why?**

**If concerns are raised by the stakeholders, how could you address these to mitigate any potential conflict?**

**Scenario Four:**

In preparation for the transition phase of the newly renovated 'Snappy Appy' offices, you want the handover to be as smooth as possible while making sure that there is minimal impact on the business itself.

**What kind of considerations should be included in your Transition Plan to ensure that the handover to the business is as seamless as possible?**

**How could your Transition Plan be used with the Senior Leadership Team and other stakeholders to ensure that they are engaged?**

## Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Leadership section:

- Which actions might enable a 'smooth' transition between delivery and the operational environment and what is the role of the project manager in relation to these actions?
- When would you recommend that change impact analysis is undertaken and what are the benefits of doing this?
- How might an extended life cycle approach impact on transition accountabilities and responsibilities?
- What steps could a project manager take to agree a transition plan with stakeholders?
- Reflect on the possibility of residual risks upon the completion of a project and what steps need to be undertaken to ensure these continue to be managed?
- The transition phase can often be a source of conflict. Why might this be the case?
- How does the project manager play a key part in ensuring that knowledge transfer happens during the transition process?

## Exam practice questions

**8.1** The approach adopted for transition of project-based outcomes into use in business-as-usual can include a Change Impact Analysis at the start of a project.

Which of the following need not be considered in this analysis?  
(1 mark)

- a. Feelings about the change in operation.
- b. Gaps in knowledge and skill that need to be addressed.
- c. Project monitoring and reporting.
- d. Process impacts of the project on the wider system.

**8.2** You are managing a project to develop a new payroll system for your organisation. During the Build, Test, and Deployment phases, the project team gained a lot of useful expertise on the new system and how it operates.

Which of the following is a crucial activity to plan as part of the project's Transition phase?  
(1 mark)

- a. Sharing the details of your system's future costs with suppliers.
- b. Adjusting the scope of your current project schedule.
- c. Sharing knowledge of how the system operates with the business users.
- d. Deciding the development approach for your next system development project.

**8.3** Engaging stakeholders to agree on a transition plan requires effective communication, collaboration, and negotiation.

Which combination of steps below would help achieve this?  
(1 mark)

- 1. Engage stakeholders early and often.
- 2. Run a benefits workshop once outputs have been delivered.
- 3. Facilitate collaborative discussions.
- 4. Discuss resource allocation weekly.
- 5. Document agreements and decisions.
- 6. Review the project's communication plan.

Select the correct combination of three options:

- a. 1,3,5
- b. 2,3,6
- c. 2,4,5
- d. 1,4,6

**8.4** What are three key outcomes that you aim to achieve when transitioning a project, and what are two potential consequences if the transition is poorly managed?  
(5 marks)

**8.5** What is the optimal time in the project life cycle to engage with stakeholders regarding the transition plan and why?  
(2 marks)



**8.6** You are the project manager for the development of your organisation's new intranet system. You should start transition planning \_\_\_\_\_(a)\_\_\_\_\_.

The relationship between the project team and those responsible for adoption in business-as-usual needs to be carefully managed. \_\_\_\_\_(b)\_\_\_\_\_ activities can help to ensure that the end users of the system are fully bought into the change.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. At the beginning of a project
2. When all deliverables are decided
3. At the end of the definition phase
4. When stakeholders are satisfied

(b)

1. Team building
2. Risk identification
3. Business readiness
4. Budget review

## Exam practice answers

| Question | Answer / Mark Scheme                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8.1      | C                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 8.2      | C                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 8.3      | A                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 8.4      | <p>1 mark for each valid outcome of transitioning a project, 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Knowledge transfer.</li> <li>• Continuous improvement.</li> <li>• Lessons learned.</li> <li>• Formal acceptance by the business.</li> <li>• Transfer of responsibility / ownership.</li> </ul> <p>1 mark for each valid consequence of a poorly managed transition, 2 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Reduced benefits.</li> <li>• Delays to timescales.</li> <li>• Increased costs.</li> <li>• Increased demand for resources.</li> <li>• Loss of reputation.</li> <li>• Disengagement of stakeholders.</li> <li>• Loss of sponsor confidence.</li> <li>• Reduces chance of project success.</li> <li>• Misaligned requirements meaning outputs aren't fit for purpose.</li> </ul> |
| 8.5      | <p>1 mark for stating the optimal time is early:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Early engagement in the project / early in the life cycle.</li> </ul> <p>1 mark for stating the reason why – any one of the below:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• To build / ensure stakeholder buy-in and support for the project.</li> <li>• To reduce the risks of stakeholders not adopting the project outputs.</li> <li>• To make sure stakeholders' expectations are clear in what the project is going to deliver.</li> <li>• To be clear what will be expected from stakeholders in the transition.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 8.6      | <p>(a) 1<br/>(b) 3</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |